

THE SIGNIFICANCE
OF BIBLICAL PROPHECY
FOR OUR TIME

BY

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AND

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THE PROPHETS did not talk to scholars. They talked to the ordinary man; and when the old Synagogue tradition prescribed weekly readings from the Prophets like those from the Law, it arranged that, just like the lessons from the Law, they should be read both in the original and in a vernacular translation, that is, presumably, for the benefit of the ordinary man.

Of course that was a dangerous practice. Bible reading in the vernacular always was dangerous. It gave people 'ideas'. It sometimes made them disrespectful to the powers that be, and the powers that be did not like it. There is an episode in the history of the *Haftarah* (as the weekly lesson from the Prophets read in the Synagogue is called) which in this regard I find instructive. A noted Rabbi is reported in the Mishnah to have laid it down that the 16th chapter of Ezekiel, beginning "Cause Jerusalem to know her abominations", is not to be used as a prophetic lesson. As the commentators explain (I should have thought superfluously), it is not to the credit of Jerusalem. You see the tendency, and it is the same everywhere and at all times. We must not be told about our misdeeds. It is bad for what is called, somewhat curiously, 'morale'.

I am glad to be able to say that in this particular instance the Synagogue did not make that mistake. To its credit, the objection, although from a very famous Rabbi, was overruled.

The official decision is that the chapter in question may be used as a public lesson, and should be translated and read publicly in the vernacular.

This encourages me in my layman's view that the importance of the prophets, both for their generation and for us, is not that they speak 'comfortable words' (though they do that too at times), but that they dared to say things which are very uncomfortable indeed but which happen to be true. Their interest was not in morale (so-called) but in something very different: morals.

The common conception of a Biblical prophet is that of a dancing dervish with a loud voice and an execrable temper; or, alternatively, of a smug preacher ready to call down fire from heaven on anybody who disagrees with him. In sum: a vengeful and self-righteous megalomaniac with an intolerable gift of the gab.

I submit that this picture is false. The typical Biblical prophet is the law-giver, Moses himself, who shows his people the 'paths of life'; and the one quality specifically attributed to Moses by Scripture is the quality of humility. He is the 'man of God', that is, he recognises God as man's 'dwelling place'. Pre-eminently he is the teacher, but what he teaches he has himself been taught from on high.

With this in mind, one's first thought in pondering the present significance of Biblical prophecy is a simple one. It can be crystallised in a short phrase, the phrase 'Spiritual Authority'.

Spiritual Authority is the opposite of Temporal Power. The prophet Nathan represented Spiritual Authority against the Temporal Power of King David; the prophet Elijah represented Spiritual Authority against the Temporal Power of King Ahab; the prophet Amos represented Spiritual Authority against the Temporal Power of Amaziah the priest of Bethel. The last instance is important because Temporal Power is not only the direct power of kings. It is all power (in our day, the power of Big Business, the power of the Press, the power of the Trade Union, the power of the Church) as well as the power of kings. Wherever and whenever there is organisation on a large

scale—a corporation, a monopoly, a government—there conscience takes second place and right is endangered.

Biblical prophecy is the resurgence of conscience. It is the affirmation that conscience comes first. "Thou art the man." "Hast thou killed, and also taken possession?" "Hear ye this, O ye that would swallow up the needy, and cause the poor of the land to fail, saying, When will the new moon be gone that we may sell corn? and the Sabbath, that we may set forth wheat? making the ephah small, and the shekel great, and dealing falsely with balances of deceit; that we may buy the poor for silver and the needy for a pair of shoes, and sell the refuse of the wheat . . . Shall not the land tremble for this?" And, in the prophetic view, it was for this that the land did tremble. Temporal power was struck down for moral sin; and moral sin means cruelty, ill-treatment of the weak, the oppression of the stranger within the gate. When the land was laid waste and its people deported, the prophets saw it as a judgment.

Spiritual Authority—Temporal Power. They still exist, and the opposition between them exists still. Indeed, to judge by our own experience, the opposition between them is fiercer now than ever before. But in our day a new element has been added. With progress, matters have become more complicated. The modern, the all too modern, world has elaborated something new which cuts across the old distinction. There is no longer the bare cleavage between Spiritual Authority on the one hand and Temporal Power on the other. We have now in addition a hybrid factor, the factor of Spiritual Power.

By Spiritual Power I do not mean what is sometimes meant by the phrase. I am not referring to what is really only the temporal power of so-called spiritual forces—the organised priesthood, the Churches and Synagogues, the vested interests of Episcopacies and Rabbinate with their binding and loosing and stoning. Power of that sort is not spiritual. It is only a variant of the treatment of Amos the prophet by Amaziah the priest of Bethel: "O thou seer, go flee thee away into the land of Judah, and eat bread there and prophesy there." By the phrase Spiritual Power I mean, literally, power over the spirit,

the 'conditioning' of the spirit, the propaganda, the mis-use of love of country and the mis-call of patriotism, the devilish misapplication of scientific knowledge and techniques in order to make 'new' men. And do not mistake. It is happening every day and all day and all the world over, not only in time of war and on the 'other side'. It is happening on 'this' side too; and the less it is noticed the more it is happening. Some writers have drawn our attention to it forcefully: the late George Orwell, for example, in his *Animal Farm* and particularly in his *1984* which, in its televised form, has just created such a stir. My only quarrel with that book is its title. It should not have been called *1984*, as if it were the expression of a fear for the future. It should have been called *1954 and 1964 and 1974*. It is a sharpened portrait of our own times. The Enemy today, as Orwell saw, is the power (not the authority) of the legend, the power (not the authority) of the lie.

A cursory glance at the Biblical prophets will show that they are constantly exhorting us to truth: to know truth, to speak truth, to seek truth, to worship the God of truth. They have the reputation of being narrowly moralistic, but their emphasis on truth suggests they realised that morality falters when it is not steadied by truth. As we might say today: intellectual integrity is a principal element in moral character.

And so to me, the most remarkable point, and the most illuminating point, in the Biblical account of prophecy, is the recognition of the existence—the real, the factual, and the terrifying existence—of *false* prophecy and *false* prophets.

The false prophets of the Bible are described as "hunters of souls". They "slay the souls that should not die" and they "save the souls alive that should not live," and they do this by "lying to my people that hearken unto lies." They "prophecy out of their own heart"; they "follow their own spirit, but they have seen nothing." They "seduce my people, saying Peace; and there is no peace."

The methods of the old false prophet were the same as those of the new: the manipulation of fact, the histrionic use of language, the endless self-praise, the merciless repetitions: "The Temple of the Lord, the Temple of the Lord, the Temple

of the Lord are these." Modern science has only refined these old weapons. It conditions and reconditions men to buy goods they do not need and to worship leaders who enslave them.

There was a novel published recently in which the methods of this 're-creating' of personality were described. In this particular case the process failed at the last moment and the man had to be, in the delicious modern idiom, liquidated. But we are all, more or less, becoming 'new men', and science knows no halt in its triumphant onward march. Applied psychology is rapidly perfecting itself. Soon a turn of a knob in a central office will give us not only new opinions but a new mind and a new heart and soul.

You will recall that these phrases—a new heart, a new spirit—are Biblical. The call to a new man is the call of the prophets; but their new man is a return to a genuine man, not a plastic toy of the propaganda machine to be manipulated and conditioned at will. The Biblical version, even in the mouth of the weary positivist Ecclesiastes, is that "God made man upright." It sees man as the son of God, as created in the likeness of God, as the child of God, as the first-born of God, as the witness of God, as little lower than the angels; and however far he may degenerate, he is stamped with the stamp of his origin. "Ye shall be holy, for I the Lord your God am holy." "These are the things that ye shall do; Speak ye every man the truth with his neighbour; execute the judgment of truth and peace in your gates: and let none of you imagine evil in your hearts against his neighbour; and love no false oath." "Wash you, make you clean; put away the evil of your doings from before mine eyes; cease to do evil; learn to do well; seek judgment, relieve the oppressed, judge the fatherless, plead for the widow."

I should be hard put to it to define the nature of Authority. It is almost as hard to define Authority as it is easy to define Power. But I think we should all agree that in these and similar utterances of Biblical prophets the voice of Authority is heard clearly. "It is not in heaven, that thou shouldest say, Who shall go up for us to heaven, and bring it unto us, and make us to hear it, that we may do it? Neither is it beyond the sea,

that thou shouldest say, Who shall go over the sea for us, and bring it unto us, and make us to hear it, that we may do it? But the word is very nigh unto thee, in thy mouth, and in thy heart, that thou mayest do it."

Bishop Butler, speaking on Conscience in a famous sermon, said: "If it had power as it has authority, it would rule the world." We have here again the same contrast, the contrast between power and authority.

The reconciliation between power and authority; between force and persuasion—"if only kings were philosophers, or philosophers kings"—is the persistent problem of mankind. In the Biblical prophets the promise of reconciliation appears under the image of the Messianic Age, "In that Day"; the day when the weak shall feel himself strong and nations shall cease to learn war: "Not by might"—the R.V. margin reads strikingly, "not by an army—and not by power but by my spirit."

A utopia? A mirage? I do not know. But we can at least keep the vision alive, and the vision is that of Biblical prophecy. It may well be that it is only by keeping that vision alive that we shall be able to keep ourselves alive.

There is one last point I should like to make. It is not really a fresh point. In principle I have made it already; indeed, I set out from it. But the application is fresh; and I hope I shall not be offending anybody if I make it. In a sense *de me fabula*. The reference is to myself and my own.

Till now I have spoken of this matter as a citizen of the world to citizens of the world. The Biblical prophets have their tale to tell. When the prophet wishes to lay down our duty in this life, he says: God "hath told thee, O man, what is good." He does not say: O Englishman, O Frenchman, even O Jew; but O man.

But the prophets had quite a lot to say to us Jews too. They promised us many comfortable things. We do well to remember those promises. But we must remember, too, the condition under which the promises were given. The promises are always limited by an 'if': "And it shall come to pass *if* ye hearken."

I sometimes think that we forget that 'if'. We claim the

promises. We are very quick to claim the promises. But we forget the condition. We forget that the promises must be earned.

But that *is* the condition, the *sine qua non*. If we "do not hearken", then we have no right to claim the fulfilment of the promises, far less to proclaim to the world that in us of this generation the promises are fulfilled.

So I think the Biblical prophets have a special lesson for us Jews over and above the general lesson they have for mankind as such. We seem to have followed the false prophets, always claiming, not always deserving. We seem always to be singing the old refrain: "The Temple of the Lord, the Temple of the Lord, the Temple of the Lord" are we. *Are* we? Like the patriotic Rabbi of the Mishnah, we ban any recital of the abominations of Jerusalem. *Should* we?

We shall have to choose pretty soon. We cannot halt forever between the two opinions. If it is to be Baal, at least let us have the honesty to say so. But let us rather follow the spirit of the old ruling that that chapter in Ezekiel should both be read in public and translated into the vernacular for the instruction of us plain men.

No doubt the politicians and diplomats will disagree. But politicians, and even diplomats, are sometimes wrong; and that, I believe—that politicians and diplomats are sometimes wrong—is one of the great, and one of the abiding, lessons which the Biblical prophets have to teach us all, Jew and non-Jew alike.